

ROSENSTONE HALL

By a Lady

FADE IN:

EXT. IN FRONT OF CASTLE - NIGHT

We OPEN on a small castle in the English countryside. There are two smaller houses to either side of the entrance plaza. The castle is lit from inside, and there seems to be some kind of reception going on. The two houses are minimally lit.

We push in closer: A group of CHATTERING LADIES is being led from the left house to the castle entrance by MR. HILL (30s, stern black-clad man).

MR HILL

Come along, ladies! The gentlemen are eager to make your acquaintance.

LADY 1

(peering towards doors)
Do you suppose they're as handsome as they say?

LADY 2

(dreamy)
If one of them is tall and titled, I shall die happy.

LADY 3

(teasing)
You'd settle for tall and breathing.

LADY 1

Laugh all you like! My sister came to this very ball three years ago and left with a count.

LADY 2

Truly?

LADY 3

My niece met her husband here last season. She's expecting her first already.

LADY 2

(squaring her shoulders)
Then I'd better make an impression.

Then DUCHESS ADELAIDE (early 20's, extravagant dress, platinum blonde in elaborate updo) and NORA (early 20's, plain dress, sleek dark hair in simple bun) walk into view.

NORA looks enraptured with the beauty and elegance of the environment, but ADELAIDE looks annoyed.

ADELAIDE
(quiet)
You shouldn't even be here.

NORA
(demure)
It was exceedingly kind of LADY CLARA to allow me to accompany you, your Grace.

ADELAIDE
I can't believe she invited my grandmother's ward. No one wants some penniless orphan traipsing around. Perhaps you should just go to the stables, find someone of your own pedigree.

NORA takes it all with a downcast look.

ADELAIDE beams a bright smile at someone off-camera as they enter the castle, already neglecting NORA.

INT. CASTLE ENTRANCE - NIGHT

SERVANTS are lined to either side of the entrance hall and LADY CLARA OF YORK (50s, overly made up, height of fashion) greets the incoming ladies with open arms and a broad smile.

LADY CLARA
Welcome, welcome! I'm so glad you could all make it. Ah, such lovely young ladies you are. You are sure to turn a few heads, yes indeed!

A few of the LADIES titter in excitement and ADELAIDE radiates pride and arrogance. NORA stays at the back.

LADY CLARA (CONT'D)
The grand ball is in just two days, so make the best of your time to get to know each other. As you know, my annual balls are known to inspire romance...

LADIES
(whooping)

LADY CLARA

But! I of course expect you to maintain *proper decorum*. We wouldn't want to have to rush any of your upcoming nuptials, now would we? Although I'm sure that Reverend Shaw would be more than happy to oblige any particularly *impatient* young lovers.

LADY CLARA observes the gathered women. Most look excited, and at least one seems lustful. NORA shrinks away from her inspecting look.

LADY CLARA (CONT'D)

Now, I won't hold you in suspense any longer. Let the mingling begin!

Two SERVANTS open the double doors to the CASTLE PARLOUR.

INT. CASTLE PARLOUR - NIGHT

In the next room, more SERVANTS are waiting with trays of champagne. Further in, various GENTLEMEN are standing in small conversational groups.

The LADIES eagerly spread through the estate, introducing themselves to the charming gentlemen.

ADELAIDE gives NORA one last sideways glance as they both enter the room.

ADELAIDE

(whispered)

Stay out of my way.

ADELAIDE is almost immediately approached by three GENTLEMEN competing for her attention, and she laughs animatedly as she lets them lead her further inside.

NORA looks overwhelmed. She hangs back, sticks to the wall, and clutches her drink like it will defend her. We follow her gaze: she looks back at the entrance, then at ADELAIDE disappearing further inside, and finally a servants' door where a SERVANT enters with a plate of appetizers.

The SERVANT offers NORA an appetizer, which she shyly declines. The SERVANT moves on, and NORA inches closer to the servants' door.

While NORA is watching her exit strategy, we see that across the room JOHN REEVES (late 20's, blond, athletic, dressed in light colours and with a large baby blue bow around his neck) is watching NORA with interest. He is twirling his drink and he smirks darkly.

Over REEVES' shoulder we see FREDERICK ASHCOMBE (early 30's, ginger, dressed in earth tones) approach NORA with a formal bow.

ASHCOMBE
How do you do, miss...?

NORA
(startled)
Oh! Miss Nora Chandler.

She curties.

ASHCOMBE
(smiling)
Miss Chandler, enchanted. My name
is Frederick Ashcombe. I trust you
had a pleasant journey?

Whenever we see ASHCOMBE, we also see REEVES in the background, observing, slightly out of focus.

NORA
I... Yes, thank you sir.

NORA glances wistfully at the entrance.

ASHCOMBE
And your family? They are all in
good health?

NORA winces slightly.

NORA
(softly)
I have none, sir. If... If you'll
excuse me...

NORA curties and all but flees out the entrance again. ASHCOMBE huffs and straightens his coat jacket before wandering back into the party.

REEVES finishes his drink with a large swig, sets it aside and strolls out towards the exit NORA just took.